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Case Study

Attracting tourists to Singapore's Chinatown: a case study in conservation and promotion

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Abstract

The case study concerns Singapore's Chinatown which occupies an important place in the country's history and has acquired major significance as a tourist attraction. Whilst much of the area was saved from the urban redevelopment characteristic of Singapore in the period since its independence and its conservation has become an official priority, approaches adopted towards the presentation and interpretation of the site have changed over time and are now a matter of public debate. Interest has increased recently as a result of the announcement of a new development programme which is outlined after a brief history of Chinatown. An account of the responses and concerns about the future then follows. Despite the very distinctive characteristics of Chinatown, events there raise general questions about the use of heritage as a tourist attraction including matters of authenticity and local involvement as well as those relating to the applicability of the life cycle model; these themes are addressed in the final section which presents some general conclusions based on the particular circumstances of the case. © 2000 Elsevier Science Ltd. All rights reserved.

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1. Introduction

The Chinese diaspora has resulted in a large population living outside of China, principally in Asia with significant numbers in Europe and North America. It has been estimated that this population numbered over 30 million in 1990 (Pan, 1998) and continued expansion is likely to have taken place since then. Early Chinese settlers overseas often gathered together in communities, many of which still exist as Chinatowns throughout the world and represent important tourist sites in cities including London, San Francisco, Sydney, Vancouver and Yokohama. The characteristics of such ethnic enclaves as living communities and tourist attractions has recently attracted the interest of academics like Conforti (1996) whose studies address questions of place presentation, promotion, planning and participation.

Many of these issues are raised by the case of Singapore's Chinatown which has played an important part in the country's history, with an official commitment to its conservation since the 1980s. It continues to evolve as a living and working community, but that community is under threat from tourism as the government intensifies efforts to develop and promote it as a destination for tourists with the launch of an ambitious programme for its revitalisation which critics have argued will turn the area into a theme park.

This study considers some of the important features of Chinatown's history and changes in attitudes towards its conservation. The final section returns to the broader themes of participatory planning, authenticity and destination life cycles in an attempt to extend the discussion and permit some more general conclusions to be derived. While acknowledging the uniqueness of Singapore's Chinatown, these would appear to be matters that affect many such areas of this type and have relevance for the continuing debate about urban heritage conservation in general and the use of that which is conserved as a tourist attraction.

2. A brief history

2.1. The origins of Chinatown

Chinatown was created in the early decades of the 19th century when Stamford Raffles, who had claimed

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Singapore for the British in 1819, set up a Town Committee to plan a new town which would accommodate the many different ethnic groups who had been attracted to the port and set aside areas for commercial and civic use. He was concerned about the rapid expansion of the original settlement and wanted to impose some order on its development. The Chinese were allocated a town south of the Singapore River with a kampong adjoining to allow for further growth, beyond that there was unexplored forest and jungle. Other races including the Chuliahs, Arabs and Bugis were located in kampongs, or villages, north of the river with the central district given over to the European Town, administration and business.

Chinatown grew quickly as immigrants arrived mainly from the southern Chinese provinces with a variety of dialect groups such as the Hokkiens, Teochews, Cantonese, Hainanese, Hakkas and Foochows which each formed their own communities. Such a mix is reflected in the cuisine of today, a series of different temples and a variety of clan associations. The distinctive architecture of shophouses which they created where the ground floor is used as shop space while the owners live above was influenced by Chinese Fujian style as well as that of the Straits Chinese who came from Malacca. Plots of land were divided into long narrow strips and houses built stretching far back for as much as 45.7 m and fronted by a pedestrian walkway or five foot way. Shophouses display great diversity from the basic original Early Shophouse Style (1840–1900) to the more flamboyant Late Shophouse Style (1900–1940) and those that remain are a feature of great interest to tourists (Urban Redevelopment Authority, undated).

From a population of just over 1000 in 1821, numbers reached almost 14,000 in 1836, 25 and 46 per cent of Singapore's total, respectively, with contemporary maps indicating a period of intense urbanisation stimulated by the trading opportunities brought to the port as a result of the opening of the Suez Canal. By the turn of the century, Chinatown had spread south and west with some land reclamation offshore and the population was 164,041. It was in these years that many important cultural institutions were founded, several of which are still notable landmarks. Also at this time, the noise and congestion became too much for many residents and the more affluent started to move out.

2.2. Living conditions

As the population expanded, there were mounting concerns about living conditions in Chinatown with evidence of overcrowding, congestion and pollution. Many inhabitants were coolies or labourers who shared the same sleeping space in cubicles in coolie lodging houses with little sanitation and limited access to fresh water. They faced poverty, malnutrition and had no proper medical facilities, despite the high incidence of contagious diseases including tuberculosis. In addition, secret societies, gang crime, opium smoking and prostitution were rampant. The area became the centre of the Chinese coolie trade where unsuspecting coolies were bought and sold, then shipped on overseas. The streets were also full of hawkers selling a variety of goods from cooked food to household wares, operating on foot all day and later crowding narrow passages with their stalls.

Yet early travellers were drawn to Chinatown and found street life and the roadside culture colourful and entertaining, while still being shocked by the squalor present in many parts. It seemed to epitomise the exotic Orient and 'the diversity of forms, shapes, colours and people of the street scenes best reinforced the Westerner's romantic conception of the picturesque' (Savage, 1992, p. 17).

Conditions deteriorated further after the Second World War and Japanese Occupation when parts of the town were badly bombed, destroying homes and businesses. There was a government enquiry in 1947 (Kiat, 1947) and a later report by Kaye (1960) documented the appalling life for many inhabitants of Chinatown. The particular concern was about overcrowding which was partly a result of the subtenanting practice of dividing and further subdividing rooms, the most dilapidated buildings often the worst affected. The back-to-back rows upon rows of shophouses had steep staircases leading to the living quarters above which were divided by partitions into cubicles, about the width of two double beds. Cubicles were often shared by households with as many as seven family members. There was a common kitchen, bathroom and lavatory in each building and originally night soil had to be carried through the house when collected because there were no back lanes. It is perhaps worth bearing these facts in mind in any discussion of the restoration of Chinatown and the invitation of promotional literature to come and see Chinatown as it once was.

2.3. Change and improvement

Some improvement was attempted by the colonial authorities, but significant change only came with Singapore's independence firstly from the British and then from the Malayan Federation in 1965. The government was committed to raising the living standards of the population and the public provision of better housing became a key objective. A number of development agencies and United Nations advisers were also proposing comprehensive urban renewal programmes which demanded extensive land clearance, especially in the city centre. The Urban Renewal Department of the Housing and Development Board, the forerunner of the present Urban Redevelopment Authority (URA), was given responsibility for Chinatown and started a programme of redevelopment and resettlement in association with other

official agencies. Hawkers were gradually cleared off the streets and relocated in permanent hawker centres while shophouses were demolished to make way for blocks of flats, a policy that continued from the 1960s until the 1980s and created great changes to the appearance, atmosphere and activities of Chinatown. Part of the philosophy underlying this policy was the integration of ethnic communities to forge a sense of national identity as different racial groups were placed together in the new public housing blocks, representing a complete break with the past and the Raffles plan of ethnic enclaves.

Chinatown thus occupies a special place in the history of Singapore. It owes its origin to Stamford Raffles, generally considered the founder of modern Singapore, and grew with the port to become a centre of the trade and commercial activity responsible for Singapore's early prosperity. It indicates the contribution that the Chinese have made to the country and the strength of their culture. From the beginning, it also functioned as a tourist attraction with a fascination for many westerners.

However, it came to symbolise a past that the new republic of Singapore wished to move on from, with the area having no role in the modern city state that the government planned and was in a hurry to realise. There was little sympathy with the notion of conservation of what was considered a crowded and unhealthy district where the trades conducted did not belong to a 20th century 'tropical city of excellence' (Liu, 1997, p. 31), the phrase adopted by the planning authorities to describe their future vision of Singapore. There was no legislation or overall government policy on conservation, few incentives to conserve and a reluctance amongst investors to put money into conservation. The official view was expressed by the Minister for National Development who said in 1980 that it was not practical to preserve most of the buildings in Chinatown because of their poor structural condition (Powell, 1994). Conservation was considered incompatible with development and prevented an area from reaching its full economic potential.

3. Conservation in the 1980s

3.1. A new attitude

There was a change in attitude in the 1980s as officials recognised the value of conservation and popular awareness of the possible disappearance of irreplaceable aspects of the country's heritage increased, an indication of the latter being the founding of the Singapore Heritage Society in 1998. Chinatown was acknowledged as a unique district, worthy of preservation in the interests of the resident population, but also as a tourist site. The year of 1984 was seen as a turning point when the government accepted a report by the URA setting up a pilot conservation project in the Tanjong Pagar district, one especially rich in shophouse architecture.

Smith (1988) has explained the shift in government policy towards conservation as a result of a sudden decline in visitor arrivals and its impact on hotel occupancy levels. Inbound tourism had been increasing at an average rate in excess of 10 per cent up until 1982 when there was a fall of 4.5 per cent, leading to the danger of overcapacity in the accommodation sector as hotels were doubling their room stock in anticipation of continued growth. In response to this potential crisis, the government appointed a Tourism Task Force to consider the problems and possible solutions. The Report of the Tourism Task Force in 1984 (Wong et al., 1984) highlighted the three main problems of perceptions of Singapore as an expensive destination with few tourist attractions and adversely affected by foreign protectionism. It recognised that some historical sites had disappeared because of development and there was a subsequent risk of Singapore losing its distinctive heritage which appealed to many visitors. In the words of the report, 'in our effort to build up a modern metropolis, we have removed aspects of our Oriental mystique and charm which are best symbolised in old buildings, traditional activities and bustling road side activities' (p.6). There was thus a strong economic case for preserving and restoring Chinatown and other historical sites, one of the Report's principal recommendations.

3.2. Conservation initiatives

Conservation became a key theme of subsequent studies such as those commissioned by the Singapore Tourist Promotion Board (STPB) from Pannell, Kerr, Forster Consultants (1986) and another prepared by the Pacific Area Travel Association (PATA, 1985) which together with the Task Force report formed the basis for the official Tourism Product Development Plan prepared in 1986 (MTI and STPB, 1986). The Plan was a joint initiative of the STPB and the Ministry of Trade and Industry and proposed using six themes to promote and develop Singapore as a tourist destination with the intention of attracting more visitors and spending. The Exotic East and Colonial Heritage were themes which involved the conservation of various historic areas and places including Chinatown and incorporated proposals for its revitalisation.

A Conservation Plan was devised for Chinatown which had the following objectives:

(a) To retain and restore buildings of historical and architectural significance.

(b) To improve the general physical environment and to introduce appropriate new features to further enhance the identity of the area.

(c) To retain and enhance ethnic-based activities while consolidating the area with new and compatible activities.

(d) To involve both the public and private sectors in carrying out conservation projects.

Conservation has since been carried out by a combination of measures. The URA completed the Tanjong Pagar pilot scheme and had restored 32 shophouses by 1988 while government purchased derelict and poorly maintained buildings and sites which were put out to tender for private conservation under the supervision of the URA. Existing owners were also encouraged to conserve their properties, again supervised by the URA. The implementation of the plan is described by the URA its guide to the Historic District of Chinatown (1995) where it claims 'with many of the fundamentals taken care of, its attention is now focused on quality restoration' (p. 1). A measure of its success was the gazetting, or official listing, of Chinatown as a conservation area in 1989 which guarantees a degree of protection from development and conformity to certain standards and procedures with regard to alterations in use and appearance.

As the plan progressed, changes became obvious with the restoration of rows of shophouses and the arrival of new businesses and private tenants. Areas were also pedestrianised and environmental improvements made such as tree planting and other forms of landscaping.

At the same time, Chinatown was given greater prominence in the Tourist Promotion Board's marketing and advertising campaigns. Tour companies were encouraged to include it in their itineraries and formally registered guides expected to be knowledgeable about the area's history, buildings and traditions.

These developments were not without their critics who complained that the Chinatown being conserved and promoted lacked the character and authenticity of the original. High rents for business and residential properties were making it impossible for local people to live and work there, and genuine traditional trades were disappearing to be replaced by fashionable restaurants, expensive boutiques, souvenir shops and smart offices. Gentrification appeared to be taking place with local people gaining little benefit and actually at risk of disinheritance.

By the end of the 1980s then, Chinatown was assuming a new importance as a heritage site of significance for both residents and visitors and this was part of a wider process of increased awareness of and commitment to heritage conservation illustrated at the start of the new decade when the various programmes under the supervision of the URA (1991a) were merged and a single Concept Plan produced for the island (1991b). The subject was not without controversy, however, related to matters of preservation, restoration and interpretation, especially within the context of Chinatown. Such concerns intensified in the 1990s with Chinatown's continued promotion as a tourist attraction and more criticisms of it being turned into a theme park from which locals were excluded.

4. Chinatown in the 1990s

4.1. Tourism 21

The Tourism Product Development Plan was to run until 1990, but it still influenced policy until the launch of the Tourism 21 initiative in 1995 (STPB, 1995) after a national tourism planning exercise. The new strategy seeks to establish Singapore as a Tourism Capital for the 21st century, performing the roles of outstanding tourist destination, tourism business centre and tourism hub for the region. The six strategic thrusts are presented of redefining tourism, reformulating the product, developing tourism as an industry, configuring new tourism space, partnering for success and championing tourism. As part of the second thrust, 11 thematic zones have been identified, in accordance with the urban design plans laid out by the URA in its Development Guide Plans, to impose a unifying character on existing products. Ethnic Singapore is one such zone and Chinatown listed as an 'opportunity area' alongside Little India, Geylang Serai and Katong/Joo Chiat (the other traditional ethnic areas) with a 'story' of 'a celebration of diversity'.

The strategy document describes the need to formulate an 'Experience Guide Plan' which will set out what kind of experience the visitor should have and an appropriate plan for the area. In the case of Chinatown, its significance 'can be enhanced if its various streets, buildings and parks were further integrated into a single themed development. This will ensure that the development of separate activities within the area is coordinated, both in terms of timing and visual impact' (p. 28). Improved 'hardware' will include an interpretative centre, better lighting and information boards while 'software' involves cultural trails, specialist guides and events and activities. The purpose is to give visitors more things to see and do in Singapore, encourage a longer length of stay and provide them with strong reasons to return — thereby maximising tourist expenditure.

Progress towards implementation of the strategy was interrupted by the onset of the Asian financial crisis in 1997 which had an adverse effect on visitor arrivals throughout the region with Singapore experiencing a fall in numbers for the first time in over a decade, of as much as 20 per cent in the opening months of 1998 (STB, 1998a). The goal of 10 million arrivals by the year 2000 was thus postponed for another five years. However, the downturn drew attention to the importance of tourism to Singapore's economy and government still allocates it a high priority, continuing to pursue the objectives set out in Tourism 21.

4.2. Restoring life to Chinatown

Even before Tourism 21 and since 1989, the URA has attempted to restore street life and a sense of bustling

community to Chinatown, working with the Singapore Tourist Promotion Board (which changed its name to the Singapore Tourism Board — STB — in 1997) in an effort to maintain a balance between preserving the old and meeting the demands of the present. Infrastructure has been improved, in association with the Land Transport Authority, and new substations now allow the shophouses to be fully air conditioned. Extensive restoration of many of the traditional Chinese Baroque style buildings has been completed and landscaping carried out. Work has started on implementing a pedestrian network masterplan which ties in with a project to create bazaar-type malls in some streets. According to the Head of Conservation at the URA, this is 'part of the Government's overall vision to revitalise Chinatown by developing a pedestrian-friendly environment that will provide the people better access to shops and facilities, and thereby encouraging a more active streetlife' (Lee, 1997). These measures are also aimed at easing the traffic problems in places where the narrow streets are congested by the large numbers of tour coaches.

The URA has laid down guidelines encouraging street level shops in the core area, and stated that such shops should be retailers selling traditional Chinese products and services or food outlets rather than offices. The National Arts Council has acquired some units to be given to various literary and performing arts groups including those specialising in Beijing opera, Chinese classical music and Mandarin or bilingual theatre at a heavily subsidised rent under its Arts Housing Scheme.

As an example of a joint public–private sector partnership in conservation which seeks to achieve the equilibrium between old and new previously referred to, the URA awarded a tender to develop one of the parcels of land in Chinatown into Far East Square. Six blocks have been devoted to conservation with 61 shophouses restored at the developer's expense and the seventh to be an ultra-modern glass building housing commercial premises. The developer has also funded the restoration of Singapore's oldest known temple, Fuk Tak Chi, into a street museum with the National Heritage Board acting as a consultant and incorporated a new Cultural Pavilion into the scheme to be used for cultural performances and arts exhibitions. Both of these sites will feature in a Heritage Trail conceptualised by the National Heritage Board which includes the Chor Eng Institute, one of the oldest free Chinese schools. Former shop tenants around the area have also been invited to move back. The project is now approaching completion.

Whether this particular development will succeed in its intentions of transforming the area and blending the old and new in an effective and stimulating way remains to be seen. One problem might be the high rental costs and the list of food and beverage operators which includes names like Spinelli, Canadian Muffin Co and Kentucky Fried Chicken suggests established and international chains might dominate. The old Chor Eng Institute is to become a restaurant and discotheque with others offering Mediterranean, French and Italian cuisine. It is anticipated that retail outlets will sell books and antiques, amongst other goods, and some will be devoted to services like banking (Chin, 1998). Such activities and resultant atmosphere would appear to exclude traditional hawkers and street life with West predominating over East rather than the exciting combination implicit in the current Tourist Board slogan of Singapore: New Asia which is discussed more fully later.

4.3. Continued revitalisation

A more ambitious initiative aimed at realising the vision set out in Tourism 21 was launched in late 1998 by the STB which announced that it was spending S$97.5 million on redeveloping Chinatown. The Finance Minister with responsibility said that, 'these efforts should not be mistaken as an attempt to re-create Chinatown. Rather, we are recalling and revitalising the Chinatown spirit so fondly remembered by Singaporeans and visitors alike, and in the process bringing forth those attributes that made this area so unique and special in our heritage' (Yap, 1998). The key elements of the project are summarised below.

- A total area of about 85 hectares will be divided into three zones — Greater Town which will have a village theatre, museum and themed streets; Historic District where historic landmarks will remain; and Hilltown which will house pubs, cafes and a mini-waterfall garden. Each district will be colour-coded and have its own distinct signs and street furnishing.
- There will be four themed streets — Bazaar Street with street traders selling textiles, home decorations and curios; Market Square where it will be possible to buy wet market goods on one side and then have them cooked at food stalls on the other; Food Street with open air cooking and dining provided by itinerant hawkers; and Tradition Street to be full of craftsmen and traders such as barbers, clog makers and medicine men. These names have been given to existing streets and it is unclear whether they will be used alongside the original ones or replace them.
- A village theatre will host a variety of cultural performances including wayangs, poetry readings and martial arts and there will be street performers, activities and events throughout the year. A Resource Centre is to incorporate a museum with interactive exhibits which will provide an insight into the evolution of Chinatown and its inhabitants.
- Five theme gardens are to be constructed based on the traditional Chinese elements of earth, fire, water, metal and wood. The gardens will be illuminated at night.

Streets will also be planted with flowering plants to add colour and trees to provide shade.
- Communications and accessibility will be improved when a new Chinatown Mass Rapid Transport (MRT) station opens and an internal bus system will connect the main attractions and carparks. There is even a possibility that trishaws will return.

The aim of the Board is to increase the number of tourists visiting Chinatown from the existing 47–70 per cent of total arrivals and to ensure that they stay there longer that the average of 2 hours, leaving with a better appreciation of Singapore's history and having spent more money. However, it also stresses that local people will gain from the changes with developers encouraged to present plans for residential properties and opportunities for new businesses to start up or existing ones to expand and diversify. Chinatown will become an area in which everyone will want to spend time because of the attractions and activities on offer.

4.4. Singapore New Asia branding

One aim guiding the authorities in their efforts to develop Chinatown has been the desire to combine old and new, as well as East and West, in a harmonious way to satisfy the demands of the tourism industry as well as meet the needs of residents. This is reflected in the STB slogan of Singapore New Asia which it has employed as a brand since 1996, hoping to convey the exciting mix that exists in Singapore, 'a city with its head in the future and its soul in the past'. Thus, the latest in modern technology co-exists with traditional values and customs in a young nation which looks ahead but does not forget its heritage; fusion is the key word often employed to describe the intended end result.

The effectiveness of such a branding exercise might be questioned with a degree of confusion amongst both residents and visitors about what the brand name actually signifies. The weaknesses of the concept are perhaps illustrated by Far East Square with its uneasy combination of the past and present and the site in Chinatown where a pub called Pop Cat painted bright blue and decorated with large yellow flowers stands close to traditional Chinese medicine halls, creating what some might perceive as a sense of incongruity and discord. The uncertainty was recognised by the STB at a recent conference where proposals were presented for a programme of popular education in which all Singaporeans were to be encouraged to 'live the values of the brand' (STB, 1998b). It could be argued that it is the marketeers who are confused and the brand should reflect contemporary life rather than dictate it, an argument which suggests the dangers inherent in place branding, marketing and commodification discussed by Teo and Yeoh (1997) within the context of Singapore.

Matters of design also arise and the need for harmonious new development and sympathetic restoration, employing appropriate colours and materials. The restored shophouses in Chinatown are often criticised for the very bright paints used externally which create an impression of newness and of a stage set, contrasting markedly with the dark and sombre hues of the older properties and their worn appearance. Modern signs and other items like air-conditioning units can also add a discordant element.

4.5. Responses

Immediate responses to the project were mixed and reflect the dilemmas involved and the potential for conflicts. Press reports indicated support from the tourism industry as the visitor experience of Chinatown would be extended and enhanced, while an academic expressed concern about the possible lack of spontaneity and over organisation. One long-term resident looked forward to a return to life of the area, although recognised that the original atmosphere could never be recreated, 'the Chinatown I grew up in cannot come back again. It was quite dirty and unhygenic. People slaughtered chickens and ducks, while others cooked next to them. They would also bathe and clean at the public taps' (Yeo, 1998).

A detailed critique was presented by the Singapore Heritage Society, again in a newspaper article (The Sunday Times, 1998) and it should be noted that The Straits Times and Sunday Times are an important medium in Singapore for official communications and public debate. It claims that the 'new' Chinatown is an artificial creation which excludes several interesting and important sites and areas, failing to take into account the fluidity of its borders. There is also an over emphasis on the Mandarin language at the expense of other significant dialects, and a neglect of the cultures which have shaped Chinatown besides that of the Chinese. The authors write of a 'freeze-frame theme park' which includes inappropriate elements such as the gardens, other greenery and colour coordinated furniture and signage which have no place in the Chinatown of the past or present. What is being offered is an 'Orientalist caricature' based on 'simplistic and exoticised cultural conceptions' designed to satisfy the needs of the tourism industry rather than the local community. Tourists themselves will be cheated by the experience and soon realise that a theme park is no substitute for a genuine community going about its everyday business. In the long term, visitor arrivals will fall instead of being stimulated as intended.

The article calls for spontaneous growth and the evolution of Chinatown without excessive interference, regulation and management. Broad guidelines and incentives could be introduced if necessary, and local people must be consulted about their feelings and opinions before any fundamental changes are made. Such sentiments were

echoed by a series of letters to the press following the publication of the article in which the writers warned of the danger of Chinatown losing its authenticity to become merely a packaged experience for the visitor, alienating and excluding residents. Several also pointed to the irony of a policy to bring back to the streets the life, colour, sights and smells of former days when government had devoted earlier efforts to their removal.

In response to the expression of these views, the STB defended its policies and sought to reassure those concerned that the guiding philosophy was to 'acknowledge, respect and preserve the unique character of the area' with the proposed developments introducing 'enhancement elements that are enduring, genuine and sustainable, rather than gimmicky and short-lived'. There had been discussions with many interested parties and stakeholders including the local Revitalisation of Chinatown, Citizens Consultative and Chinatown Retailers Pro-tem Committees as well as numerous official agencies. A process of consultation was said to be underway and feedback was invited (Anon, 1998).

At this stage, it is difficult to comment on the extent to which the most recent proposals will be implemented and their consequences. Public interest has led to the announcement of further consultation with local residents and other groups and there is a possibility of some modifications being made. Nevertheless, it would appear that Chinatown is changing and assuming a different identity. While places evolve over time and Chinatown's history has been one of constant and rapid change, the concern remains that these changes and new identity are being forced upon it by external agencies to create a manufactured sense of place. The image of a theme park is often invoked by critics with the Chinatown of the future described as such an attraction in which locals have no place, except as paid employees. Chinatown as a community of residents and workers will thus cease to exist, and there is a strong feeling that the people who make up this community have not as yet been sufficiently consulted about their views.

5. Conclusions

A study of Chinatown and its development raises interesting and topical issues relating to the search for authenticity in the conservation of heritage and its presentation as a tourist attraction, the role of local people in the planning process and the applicability of the life cycle model. It illustrates the conflicting interests at work, the need to achieve some kind of balance amongst them and the difficulties of securing this. The history of Singapore, its unique society of mixed races and particular political culture all add to the complexity of the case and introduce further tensions and layers of meaning. Whilst recognising that each Chinatown and similar historic sites will have a distinctive history, set of current concerns and future development patterns, it is possible to draw some general lessons from the case and these are discussed below.

5.1. Local participation

Since Murphy (1985) stressed the importance of greater involvement of the community in tourism development, this has become a widely accepted aim amongst planners with destination residents 'being seen increasingly as the nucleus of the tourism product' (Simmons, 1994, p. 98). Pearce, Moscardo and Ross (1996) write of the need for a 'more sophisticated understanding of how communities react to the burgeoning phenomenon of tourism' (p. 1) in the pursuit of improved long-term planning and discuss the value of a social representations approach. The debate has since been extended to incorporate stakeholder theories and arguments about the need to ensure that all local stakeholders contribute to planning policy making in the interests of sustainability (Sautter & Leisen, 1999).

While accepting the benefits and desirability of this participation, its practicality and viability has also been questioned and Taylor (1995) describes the perverseness that 'in approaching community members to become participants in both the tourism product and its planning, residents are encouraged to become part of the problem and then given the opportunity to become part of the solution' (p. 488). There are also difficulties of establishing appropriate and workable mechanisms for consultation and involvement and evaluating its effectiveness, especially in the developing world and Timothy (1999) lists cultural and political traditions, poor economic conditions, lack of expertise and lack of understanding by residents as constraints in the case of the Indonesian destination of Yogyakarta. Many states may also choose to set limits to the extent of public debate and exercise control over the outcome, either openly or more covertly. However, this problem is also evident in the countries of the developed world as Bramwell and Sharman (1999) reveal in their account of stakeholder collaboration in a UK case study where 'unequal power relations remained among the stakeholders with the distribution of power weighted towards the authorities rather than the residents' (p. 412).

Timothy also presents a model of participatory tourism planning which includes public consultation and locally defined goals, input from other stakeholders, involvement of locals in the benefits of tourism and the education of residents. While there is some evidence of such community participation in the decision making process in Singapore, it appears to have been arranged at a late stage in response to popular concern and adverse publicity. Greater efforts are now being made to consult, involve and educate locals and the recent STB

announcement about holding a series of dialogue sessions indicates further moves in this direction. Conditions in Chinatown thus suggest the existence of a gap between planning theory and practice, as well as the necessity of local involvement if tourism development is to succeed in the long term.

Ideally, it is not only the inhabitants of Chinatown who should have a say, but also the population of Singapore as a whole who represent important stakeholders given the national significance of the site. Teo writing independently (1994) and with Huang (1995) has described the absence of local participation in other tourism projects in Singapore and the subsequent alienation and exclusion of the resident population from what become principally tourism venues. Whenever, and wherever this happens, authenticity and meaning are lost, possibly forever.

5.2. *Authenticity and recreating the past*

The case also illustrates some of the difficulties associated with the concept of authenticity in the tourist experience, suggested by MacCannell (1976) and subsequently explored in a series of studies (Cohen, 1979; Pearce & Moscardo, 1986; Selwyn, 1996). With the emergence of an extensive literature on the topic, the subject has acquired a complexity and ambiguity so that satisfactory definitions appear elusive — especially when postmodernist discussions are considered (Eco, 1986).

A recent article by Wang (1999) provides an excellent summary of the alternative ways of assessing authenticity and offers a three-fold typology. Objective authenticity refers to that of originals, constructive authenticity is that which is projected onto objects or experiences by the tourists themselves or tourist industry and existential authenticity is that which arises from tourist activity and participation. However, it is not just the tourists and the industry, but also the state which determines forms of authenticity (Bruner, 1994) with local views often overlooked in this process.

Commentators suggest that tourists claim to search for authentic objects, sites and experiences, but often accept as authentic what might be dismissed as fake or bogus by experts and intellectuals; the authenticity they seek is thus symbolic rather than real. Objective authenticity is increasingly uncommon, being replaced by its constructive and existential forms. In some ways, reality has ceased to exist as we inhabit a postmodern world of simulacra which is well suited to a tourism industry that deals in images and idealised representations.

Tourist appreciation and understanding of authenticity is a question that merits further study as does the approach of attractions which claim to be offering it. While accepting that those involved cannot be expected to depict a site's past in all its squalor, they do have certain responsibilities with regard to giving visitors an accurate and meaningful sense of the history of a place and its contemporary realities. It is important for public and private sector providers to try to understand and meet the needs of both residents and visitors where possible whilst also striving for honesty and integrity of presentation and interpretation so that ambiguity about the type of authenticity on offer is reduced. There is a danger that presentation becomes a selective process which reflects the interests of those making the selection (Barthel, 1989) rather than the local population or indeed the tourists themselves, and that authenticity is manipulated accordingly.

Within the context of Chinatown, part of the past that the authorities wish to see return and sometimes promise to the tourists is a lively street life, usually described as 'vibrant', but the original atmosphere obviously cannot be recovered. The former hustle and bustle on the streets was a result of the dense population and overcrowded conditions which forced people out on to the footways and roads for leisure and commerce with a bazaar economy of day and night markets. Such trading disappeared as a result of the government's housing and urban renewal policies, and the establishment of a formal economy and planned city displaced the 'itinerant hawkers, pedlars and roving traders' (Savage, 1992, p. 19). As well as traders, traditional entertainments and activities like glove puppet shows and story-telling have also died out, or are in the process of doing so, as described by former practitioners in a recent oral history project (Lo-Ang & Chua, 1992).

While much of the physical landscape is capable of being restored and has acquired a degree of constructed authenticity, ways of living and street life cannot be so easily represented and it is unlikely that many residents or visitors would want to return to the harsh conditions of Chinatown and other historic sites at the turn of the century. The problem then is determining what and whose authenticity is presented to the visitor. As the authorities and tourism industry seek to create an atmosphere and environment which evokes the past and reintroduce traditional activities in modified forms, Chinatown might be seen as an attempt to devise and present a form of selective and possibly distorted authenticity which avoids areas of contention and controversy. The emphasis is on making the place an appealing one for visitors who are encouraged to spend their time and money there.

There is the additional challenge of the fact that those traditional traders who have survived are faced with high rental costs of restored properties and increases of 100 to 200 per cent on each occasion. For example, the rent for an 800 sq ft corner shop unit rose from $80 a month to $5000 in 1998 for the retailer after the shophouse was renovated (Li, 1998). These charges make it difficult for the small scale businesses to survive with their places being taken by fast food outlets, expensive restaurants

and smart offices. This objective authenticity of the present may not always match that sought by the tourist who may also be dissatisfied with the contrived versions of the past which lies uneasily alongside. Additional research into the actual responses of visitors to Chinatown and their experiences there is necessary, however, to test such observations while the attitudes of residents and the formulation of those attitudes also demands further study.

5.3. Product life cycles

The life cycle model is commonly used to analyse the evolution of tourism destinations and several versions have been proposed since the 1960s (Alex Tooman, 1997), although Butler's (1980) remains perhaps the most influential. He described the stages of the life cycle as being those of exploration, involvement, development, consolidation, stagnation, and decline or rejuvenation. The concept is not without its critics, however, who claim that it can only be a guide for planners and marketers (Cooper, 1994) while others argue that it has lost any value it once possessed. Da Conceicao and Roque Aquas (1997) summarise the limitations as 'the absence of a prescriptive model that can be widely used and unanimously accepted; the difficulty in determining to which stage products and services belong; the lack of data to support the theory; and the concept's subjective nature' (p. 14).

It is not the purpose of this paper to evaluate the product life cycle in detail, the subject already of some debate in the academic press (Singh, 1998), but it can be concluded that Singapore's Chinatown does conform to the model in many respects in that it appears to have followed the pattern from early discovery and exploration to maturity in its history as a tourist attraction. It is also a concept employed by the tourism authorities who frequently make use of terms such as revitalisation and rejuvenation to describe their policies. Present developments in Singapore's Chinatown can be seen as a recognition by the tourism authorities that the site has arrived at the stage of stagnation and possible decline and that the proposed changes are necessary to begin a process of rejuvenation.

However, whilst the life cycle model appears to be a useful instrument to conceptualise a destination's evolution, the question of whether such a complex entity as Chinatown and its history can be treated like a consumer product raises some doubts about the appropriateness of its application to places which are also communities. As such, these sites undergo continual change and this constant development may give rise to shifts in their identity, both in substance and perception, as tourist destinations. The life cycle model is perhaps too rigid and inflexible to capture and explain these dynamics.

Chinatown thus represents the challenges facing both conservation agencies and those responsible for presenting and promoting the heritage which is conserved to visitors. It provides an illustration of the possibilities and pitfalls of both processes and offers some interesting insights into the debate about participatory planning and the search for authenticity, as well as the appropriateness of the life cycle model. The ability to meet these challenges effectively in Singapore remains debatable with evidence of the benefits of conservation initiatives and their limitations, as well as both successful and inappropriate tourism development and moves towards greater community participation. Questions of whose heritage is being preserved, in what manner and for what purpose need to be addressed, however, to ensure that the Chinatown which emerges in the new millenium will still be a living and working community that attracts visitors for itself. Chinatown and similar sites should not be allowed to become stages for the telling of stories devised by the tourism industry to maximise the sale of its products and sanctioned by government in pursuit of wider objectives; in this way, locals are denied their rightful opportunity to participate and the visitor experience is devalued.

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